violence and made them to help him confront the legacy of war in his own family and his life. The artist recalled, “They expressed the need to purge myself of the horrors of the war. … I meant them to be a protest against the excessive amounts of money spent by governments to wage hot and cold wars.”[37] Tajiri was upset to learn that exhibitions of this work, like that held at Amsterdam’s Stedelijk Museum, were perceived by visitors as glorifying war. He proceeded to look for other ways to explore themes of war, rethinking matters of abstraction and recognition.

Responding to the reception of his own antiwar artworks, Tajiri created a series of monumental sculptural knots. He aimed for a recognizable symbol, forging it in varying patterns in polyester or bronze in his home foundry. Against the misreading of his antiwar messages and wariness over the art world’s turn toward conceptual art that at times privileged ideas over materials, Tajiri saw himself needing to fashion works of immediate perceptibility and territorial distinction. He stated of the series, “Put a knot in the middle of a jungle, and everyone knows what it means.” However, his knots, as Lambert Tegenbosch writes, do evoke the traces of hidden meanings and conceptual aims beyond their shape: “A knot joins one thing to another. Tajiri, however, leaves one and the other thing out, thus depriving the knot of its function and primary meaning.” Instead, Tegenbosch suggests that a “wealth of meanings” stem from recognition, as well as his titles, placement, and productive links with other works in his oeuvre.[38] Tajiri’s first in this series, *Granny’s Knot* (1968), was over eleven feet tall and resembled a partial bisection of a double helix. The knot conjured balance without symmetry, and solidity without continuity. (The sculpture was shown at Documenta IV, purchased by Nelson Rockefeller, and seen by students at the Hochschule der Künste, initiating their invitation for him to join their faculty.) The name of the piece refers to a common type of knot and offers a nod of familiar respect and remembrance of Tajiri’s own family. This knot was crafted as a possible gesture of reconstitution in the face of insecurity and loss.[39] He built on this by producing hundreds of other knots, each with both obvious recognition and layers of visual riddles.

As a sculptor, Tajiri found in his Berlin Wall project a space of experimentation outside his studio that was process-oriented and materially focused. While many of his projects involved intensive processes of design, mold building, casting, and installation, he deferred these in the production of his Berlin Wall survey. He sought reflection over fabrication, as he